

Photoshop Intermediate: From Practitioner to Pro

The hands-on sequel to an introductory Photoshop course. Over eight sessions you mask by tone and channel, manage color for screen and print, retouch and composite to a commercial standard, build design systems, automate, and merge multi-shot images, finishing one professional deliverable every session, then plan, build, and present a client-style capstone.

FORMAT

Instructor-led

DURATION

**8 sessions · 24
hrs**

SESSION

3 h incl. a break

LEVEL

Intermediate

HOW THE COURSE RUNS

One module, one 3-hour session, one finished deliverable. The course is built as eight modules, and every module already ends in a finished professional piece: a hard cutout, a graded image delivered for screen and print, a retouched portrait, a composite key visual, a multi-size campaign, a data-driven batch, a set of multi-shot merges, a presented capstone. So the schedule follows the modules instead of cutting across them. Each session runs every lesson's framing, live demo and guided build, with a quick self-check; each lesson's solo variation starts in class and finishes at home, so nobody goes home with half a deliverable.

The last two sessions share the capstone. **Module 7** has two lessons, so Session 7 ends with a capstone kickoff: you write your brief in class and leave with a moodboard and plan started, then build most of the piece as homework. **Session 8** is for plan review, a final studio block, the case study, presentations, and peer critique.

Weekly: one session a week for eight weeks. The week between sessions is for the solo variations on your own images and your learning journal.

Twice a week: four weeks. Keep at least two days between Sessions 7 and 8 for the capstone build.

4-day intensive: two sessions a day (morning and afternoon). Run Session 7 on the morning of Day 4 only if learners can build overnight; otherwise schedule Session 8 a few days later.

CORE CRAFT

Sessions 1–3 (Modules 1–3)

COMMERCIAL WORK

Sessions 4–6 (Modules 4–6)

GOING FURTHER

Sessions 7–8 (Modules 7–8)

SESSION SCHEDULE

Times assume a 9:00 start. Shift the whole block to fit your schedule (an afternoon or evening run works the same way). Lesson titles link to the lesson pages on the course site.

SESSION 1

Advanced Selection & Masking

CORE CRAFT

By end of session: build luminosity masks from the image's own tones, forge a mask from a channel or use Blend-If, and run a hard cutout through the full Select & Mask pipeline until every strand of hair survives.

Deliverable: a flowing-hair cutout on a new background that passes the saturated-background test (Module 1)

PART 1 Module 1 · Advanced Selection & Masking (I)

9:00–11:06

9:00		Welcome, orientation & setup check · Introductions; the path and Recipes II; color settings sanity, the 16-bit habit, and “diagnose before you edit”
9:20	L01	Luminosity Masks: Select by Tone · Lights, Darks and intersected bands from Ctrl/⌘-clicking RGB; rescue a high-contrast landscape
10:05	L02	Channel Masking & Blend-If · Pick the channel with the most contrast, Levels it into a mask; Blend-If with Alt/⌘-split sliders
10:53		Break

PART 2 Module 1 · Advanced Selection & Masking (II)

11:06–12:00

11:06	L03	Select & Mask Mastery: The Hard Cutout · Rough in, refine, rescue, decontaminate: flowing hair onto a new background (the Module 1 deliverable)
11:55		Wrap-up & exit ticket · Two-minute pressure-test gallery on a saturated background

SESSION 2

Color & Tone, Deep

CORE CRAFT

By end of session: set up a trustworthy color pipeline, build a cinematic grade with Curves and gradient maps and bottle it as a LUT, then split-tone it, soft-proof it, and deliver it for both screen and print.

Deliverable: one graded, split-toned image delivered as a web sRGB JPG and a print file, from a wide-gamut 16-bit master (Module 2)

PART 1 Module 2 · Color & Tone, Deep (I)

9:00–11:02

9:00		Warm-up: Module 1 recap + screen check · Night Light / True Tone off; what a histogram tells you before you touch a slider
9:10	L04	Color Management & Working Spaces · Color Settings once; working space vs bit depth; Assign vs Convert; read the histogram before any edit
9:55	L05	Grading with Curves, Gradient Maps & LUTs · Neutral base, a Curves look, a gradient map at low opacity; export the grade as a LUT and reuse it
10:50		Break

PART 2 Module 2 · Color & Tone, Deep (II)

11:02–12:00

11:02	L06	Match, Split-Tone & Soft-Proof · Split-tone by zone, match a second image, soft-proof with gamut warning; deliver screen and print files
11:52		Wrap-up & exit ticket · Bring a portrait you have permission to retouch next session

SESSION 3

High-End Retouching

CORE CRAFT

By end of session: take one portrait through frequency separation, dodge & burn, and a masked eyes, teeth and hair finish, and judge where to stop.

Deliverable: a finished layered portrait that passes the flip-and-mirror test (Module 3). Bring a portrait you have permission to edit and show.

PART 1 Module 3 · High-End Retouching (I)

9:00–11:05

9:00		Warm-up, recap & ground rules · Check Image ► Mode for 16-bit; consent and respect; critique the edit, not the face
9:12	L07	Skin & Frequency Separation · Low for tone and color, High for texture (16-bit Apply Image: Add, Invert, Scale 2, Offset 0)
10:05	L08	Dodge & Burn Sculpting · A 50% gray Soft Light layer; low-opacity dodge and burn to bring back form
10:52		Break

PART 2 Module 3 · High-End Retouching (II)

11:05–12:00

11:05	L09	Eyes, Teeth & Hair: Natural Finish · Local, masked, restrained: eye whites, teeth, flyaways; then an 8-minute flip-and-toggle review in pairs
11:52		Wrap-up & exit ticket

SESSION 4

Commercial Compositing

COMMERCIAL WORK

By end of session: place an element on the scene's horizon at the right scale, relight it, ground it with contact and cast shadows (and a reflection on glossy ground), then give the frame depth and one grade over everything.

Deliverable: an advertising-style key visual, exported flat in sRGB, plus the layered master (Module 4)

PART 1 Module 4 · Commercial Compositing (I)

9:00–11:00

9:00		Warm-up: Module 3 recap · “What gives a composite away?”
9:10	L10	Match Perspective, Scale & Lens · Find the horizon and vanishing point, scale by the ground, match the lens; Perspective Warp
9:57	L11	Light, Shadows & Reflections · Read the light first; relight the element; contact shadow, graduated cast shadow, reflection
10:47		Break

PART 2 Module 4 · Commercial Compositing (II)

11:00–12:00

11:00	L12	Atmosphere & the Unifying Grade · Distance has a look: haze by depth band, then one grade over everything; export the key visual
11:48	LAB	Mini-gallery: run the lesson's checklist in order
11:55		Wrap-up & exit ticket

SESSION 5

Design Systems & Type

COMMERCIAL WORK

By end of session: build a named type system with paragraph and character styles, a reusable Smart-Object mockup template with linked assets, and a campaign in every size from one master file.

Deliverable: one master file with four artboards (poster, square post, story, banner) exported in one pass, where one source edit updates every size (Module 5)

PART 1 Module 5 · Design Systems & Type (I)

9:00–10:55

9:00		Warm-up: Module 4 recap + project folder · Your Module 4 key visual becomes this session's key art
9:10	L13	Type Systems, Styles & Grids · A modular scale, Paragraph and Character Styles, a grid built from your leading
9:57	L14	Smart-Object Templates & Linked Assets · A mockup placeholder you refill with Replace Contents; embedded vs linked; Update Modified Content
10:42		Break

PART 2 Module 5 · Design Systems & Type (II)

10:55–12:00

10:55	L15	Campaign from One Master · Artboards, reflowing a design to fit, Export As for every artboard; one edit updates all four
11:55		Wrap-up & exit ticket

SESSION 6

Generative + Automation, Advanced

COMMERCIAL WORK

By end of session: give a cramped composite room, clean it and Harmonize it with generative tools; batch a mixed folder with a conditional Action and a droplet; and render one graphic per row of a CSV from a single template.

Deliverable: a folder of personalized cards exported with Data Sets as Files from one template and a CSV (Module 6)

PART 1 Module 6 · Generative + Automation (I)

9:00–10:58

9:00		Warm-up: sign-in check + Module 5 recap · Signed in, online, generative credits available
9:10	L16	Generative for Compositing · Expand, remove and add; Harmonize; limits, ethics and licensing: generative output is raw material
10:00	L17	Advanced Actions & Conditionals · Record a delivery Action, branch on orientation, batch a folder of copies, build a droplet
10:45		Break

PART 2 Module 6 · Generative + Automation (II)

10:58–12:00

10:58	L18	Data-Driven Graphics & Scripting · Variables and Data Sets from a CSV, export one file per row; where scripting begins
11:52		Wrap-up & exit ticket

SESSION 7

Multi-Shot Techniques + Capstone Kickoff

GOING FURTHER

By end of session: merge a panorama, an HDR bracket and a focus stack, keyframe a seamless loop and export it, and leave with a written capstone brief, a moodboard started, and a plan drafted.

Deliverable: a panorama, an HDR merge and a focus stack, plus a looping animation as a GIF and an MP4 (Module 7) · homework: finish the capstone plan and build most of it

PART 1 Module 7 · Multi-Shot Techniques (I)

9:00–10:18

9:00 Warm-up: Module 6 recap + practice-file check

9:10 **L19** Panoramas, HDR & Focus Stacking · Align, then blend: Photomerge, Merge to HDR Pro, Auto-Blend Layers

10:05 Break

PART 2 Module 7 · Multi-Shot Techniques (II)

10:18–12:00

10:18 **L20** Timeline Animation & Export · Frames vs keyframes; a seamless loop; export a GIF and an MP4

11:08 **CAP** **Capstone kickoff:** The Brief & the Plan (Lesson 8.1) · Write the brief in class, start the moodboard and the staged plan. Homework: finish the plan and build Passes 1 and 2 (Lesson 8.2)

11:50 Wrap-up & exit ticket

SESSION 8

Capstone: Build, Present & Case Study

GOING FURTHER

By end of session: finish a self-directed project against its brief in an organized, non-destructive file, export it at spec, and present it in context with a case study and peer critique.

Deliverable: a professional brief delivered, with its case study, presented (Module 8) · the published case study follows within a week

PART 1 Module 8 · Capstone (I)

9:00–10:37

9:00 **L21** The Brief & the Plan: plan review · Pairs: brief, moodboard and current file against the success criteria; set a studio goal

9:15 **LAB** **Studio** (Lesson 8.2): finish in passes · Step back, fresh eyes, layer hygiene; export the deliverables at spec

10:25 Break

PART 2 Module 8 · Capstone (II)

10:37–12:00

10:37 **L23** Present & Case Study: assemble · Hero image, in-context mockup, the before, and a 30-second story

11:02 **CAP** **Presentations & peer critique** (Lesson 8.3): about 4 minutes each · Present, then two reviewers score against the rubric (one glow, one grow)

11:52 Course close · Where to go next, the final journal prompt; publish the case study within a week

COURSE DETAILS

■ Requirements

- ◆ **Working Photoshop skills:** layers, masks, selections, Camera Raw, Curves, Smart Objects, and basic retouching and compositing (the introductory course or equivalent)
- ◆ A Windows or macOS computer that runs **Adobe Photoshop 2025 or newer** (the current release is recommended); the desktop app, not Photoshop on the web or iPad
- ◆ An **Adobe account** with a plan that includes Photoshop, and access to Adobe Fonts
- ◆ **Internet access and generative credits** for Session 6 (generative tools run in the cloud)
- ◆ A mouse or pen tablet; 16 GB of RAM strongly recommended for layered 16-bit files

■ What's Provided

- ◆ A **setup guide** to complete before Session 1
- ◆ The full **23-lesson** course workbook (yours to keep)
- ◆ **Practice files** for every lab, so you are never stuck without a suitable image
- ◆ The online **Recipes II library:** 28 quick, standalone how-to cards
- ◆ Guided builds in every session, a capstone studio, and peer critique
- ◆ A finished deliverable from every session, plus a presented capstone with a case study

■ Bring Your Own Images

- ◆ **S1:** a high-contrast landscape; a bare tree or power lines against a bright sky; a portrait with loose or curly hair on a fairly plain background
- ◆ **S2:** a favorite photo to grade (a portrait is ideal), a second shot from the same set in different light, and one deliberately vivid image
- ◆ **S3:** a portrait of someone who has agreed to be retouched and shown in class (a self-portrait works), large original, teeth and loose hair visible
- ◆ **S4:** a background with clear perspective and visible shadows, and a clean cutout from your Session 1 work
- ◆ **S5:** your Session 4 key visual as key art; optional: your own logo as a transparent PNG
- ◆ **S6:** your layered Session 4 composite (or a cramped photo), a folder of 8–12 mixed landscape and portrait **copies**, and a short list with photos you may use
- ◆ **S7:** a simple layered design to animate (your Session 5 master works); one or two capstone ideas with reference images
- ◆ **S8:** your capstone master, brief, moodboard and pass screenshots, built as homework from images you own or have the right to use

■ Assessment

- ◆ **Session deliverables:** each module's finished piece, checked against its lesson's Project Completion Checklist
- ◆ **Learning journal:** a short entry after every lesson, revisited in the case study
- ◆ **Capstone:** briefed, planned, built, presented, and scored on a published 12-row rubric drawn from the lessons' own checklists: brief and plan; meets the brief, composition, focal point, tonal structure; built in passes and file hygiene; the case study; and the presentation
- ◆ **Completion:** every session deliverable submitted, plus a capstone with no rubric row below 2 of 3, the deliverables exported at spec, and a layered master
- ◆ Below the bar? Targeted feedback and a resubmission

What You'll Be Able to Do

Graduates leave with a portfolio of professional deliverables and a case study that explains how they were made.

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|---|--|
| ✓ Mask by tone and channel, and cut out hair and fine detail cleanly | ✓ Manage color from working space to soft-proofed print |
| ✓ Grade with Curves, gradient maps and LUTs, and match images | ✓ Retouch a portrait to a high-end, natural standard |
| ✓ Composite with matched perspective, light, shadow and atmosphere | ✓ Build type systems, templates and multi-size campaigns |
| ✓ Use generative tools responsibly and automate with Actions and data | ✓ Brief, plan, build and present client-style work with a case study |

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v1.0 · 8 sessions · 24 hours